

Godman's SINS

A self-styled godman with friends in high places is jailed for raping minors at his orphanage in Kochi

Religion may be the opium of the masses but in Kerala, the crumbling Marxist bastion also known as God's own country, religion is the ultimate aphrodisiac for a whole lot of godmen. Last week, a Kochi court convicted the once popular and self-styled godman Swami Amrithachathanya alias Santosh Madhavan guilty in a rape case and sentenced him to 16 years rigorous imprisonment and imposed a fine of Rs 2.10 lakh. The 36-year-old was charged in two separate cases of raping three minor girls and an adult woman. The minors were inmates of an orphanage run by his Santhitheeram Trust in Kochi.

Ernakulam Additional Sessions Judge K. Haripal ordered the fine to be paid to the first prosecution witness, a minor girl, who had testified against Madhavan despite pressure to turn hostile. Three prosecution witnesses had earlier turned hostile. The clinching evidence against the accused was a video CD seized from Madhavan's bank locker which contained explicit scenes of the godman molesting a 15-year-old girl. Though the girl in the vcd later turned hostile, the judge said the scenes in the disc were strong evidence against the godman. The judge also dismissed Madhavan's claim that the CD was fabricated by the police.

The sleaze surfaced because of a mix-up by Interpol when, in May 2008, it issued a Red Corner notice for one Santhosh Madhavan after the CBI wanted him in a case related to unauthorised possession and smuggling of sophisticated arms in Mumbai. The notice on the Interpol website contained the Ernakulam-based Madhavan's photograph, age and address. On seeing his picture, a Dubai-based non-resident Keralite

businesswoman filed a complaint with the Dubai Police charging Madhavan of duping her of Rs 45 lakh. In her complaint, Seraphine Edwin alleged Madhavan had taken the money from her for a joint business venture three years ago but went missing. The Dubai Police forwarded the complaint to the Kochi

the same name. However, by this time the Kerala Police had got important clues on his misdemeanours. A raid at his luxury flat in Kochi unearthed vcds of pornographic films, tiger skins, sandalwood logs and drugs. Photograph albums showing him with political leaders, film stars and police officials were also seized. A police official was suspended for his alleged close links with Madhavan.

Subsequently, three minor girls filed complaints against Madhavan for molestation. According to the prosecution, the Swami believed sex

**SANTOSH MADHAVAN
UNDER ARREST**



Police seized pornographic films, tiger skins drugs and sandalwood from his Kochi flat.

Police which raided Madhavan's ashram, frequented until then by politicians, film stars and even police officials, ostensibly to seek astrological advice. Thanks to his highly-placed followers, the godman got a tip-off and disappeared. He appeared two days later on television channels giving interviews from his hideout, pleading innocence.

By then, Interpol clarified that Santhosh Madhavan's picture was a case of mistaken identity and they were looking for another accused by

with adolescent girls would make him more virile. On May 12 last year, the police caught up with Madhavan when he was driving around Kochi. According to the police, Madhavan, a Class-XII dropout, had started off as a petty shopkeeper, became an astrologer and eventually grew into a self-styled spiritual man with high connections and a lot of real estate. His high-profile friends have since then deserted him and for the next 16 years, the 6x6 cell will be his only real estate.

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